AN INTRODUCTION TO THE NT (D.A. CARSON & D. MOO)

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

REVELATION

CONTENTS

The structure of Revelation is hotly debated, mainly because conclusions on this matter radically affect one's understanding of the historical referents and eschatology of the book. Major divisions in the book are often based on significant repeated phrases. References to "what must come to pass," or something like it, occur in 1:1, 1:19, 4:1, and 22:6. Another such formula is John's reference to being "in the Spirit" (1:10, 4:2, 17:3, 21:10). These literary markers suggest that 1:1–20 (or 1:1–8) and 22:[6]10–21 are, respectively, the prologue and epilogue, and that the letters to the seven churches in chapters 2–3 form a separate unit. There seems to be some basis for this division in 1:19, where it is plausible to think that "what you have seen" refers to the vision in chapter 1, "what is now" to the letters in chapters 2–3, and "what will take place later" to chapters 4 and following.

The material from 4:1 to 22:5 has been structured in many different ways. The simplest is to note the places where an interruption in the visionary mode occurs and where the seer is invited to "come and see." This results in a threefold division, 4:1–16:21; 17:1–21:8; and 21:9–22:5. Others think that the section divides in half, chapters 12–22 repeating the material of chapters 1–11. The book of Revelation has been likened to a seven-act play, with seven scenes in each act. Others find a chiastic structure. More often, the three series of sevens—seals (6:1–17; 8:1), trumpets (8:2–9:21; 11:15–19), and bowls (15:1–16:21)—are used as the basis of the structure. Chapters 4–5 (or chap. 4 alone) are then viewed as an inaugural vision that sets the tone for what follows, with 17:1–22:5 giving the details of the eschatological denouement. Interrupting the sequence of events—that is, between the sixth and seventh seals (chap. 7), the sixth and seventh trumpet (10:1–11:14), and the seventh trumpet and the bowls (12:1–14:20)—are further visions that give the reader perspective on the unfolding of the septets of judgment. This last concept seems to provide the best approach to the structure, and we follow it in the outline of contents below.

Prologue (1:1–20). The book opens with a brief introduction (1:1–3), address and salutation (1:4–8), and vision of the glorified Christ (1:9–20). (Some take this vision, with chaps. 2–3, as an introduction to the letters to the seven churches.)

Messages to seven churches (2:1–3:22). John is commanded by the risen Christ to address messages to seven churches in seven cities within the Roman province of Asia: Ephesus (2:1–7), Smyrna (2:8–11), Pergamum (2:12–17), Thyatira (2:18–29), Sardis (3:1–6), Philadelphia (3:7–13), and Laodicea (3:14–22). Each letter contains (1) a greeting to the ἄγγελος (*angelos*, "angel" or "messenger") of the church; (2) a description of the risen Christ, drawn from the vision in 1:9–20; (3) praise for the church (except in the letter to Laodicea); (4) criticism of the church (except in the letters to Smyrna and Philadelphia); (5) a warning; (6) an exhortation, beginning, "Whoever has ears …"; and (7) a promise.

A vision of heaven (4:1–5:14). John is taken up to heaven "in the Spirit," where he sees the sovereign God seated on the throne and receiving worship. The transcendence of God depicted in this vision sets the stage for the drama that unfolds: John sees a sealed scroll in God's hand, and only a "Lamb, looking as if it had been slain," is accounted worthy to break the seven seals and open the scroll (5:1–14).

The seven seals (6:1–8:5). John describes what he sees as each seal is opened by the Lamb: conquest (6:1–2), slaughter (6:3–4), famine (6:5–6), death (6:7–8), martyrs crying out for justice (6:9–11), and natural disasters, signifying the "wrath of the Lamb" (6:12–17). Then, before the seventh seal is described, John sees two visions, each of them depicting a great mass of people: 144,000 from the tribes of Israel who had been sealed by God (7:1–8) and an innumerable multitude who had "come out of the great tribulation" (7:9–17). The opening of the seventh seal brings silence in heaven and the introduction of the seven trumpets (8:1–5).

The seven trumpets (8:6–11:19). In his vision, John now observes the disasters that come upon the earth as angels blow each of the trumpets: hail and fire from heaven (8:7), a mountain thrown into the sea (8:8–9), a great star falling from the sky (8:10–11), astronomical changes (8:12–13), destructive locusts (9:1–12), and a huge conquering army (9:13–21). As was the case with the seals, John interjects two visions before he narrates the events connected with the seventh trumpet. John sees an angel with a little scroll that he is instructed to eat (10:1–11) and two witnesses, who prophesy, are killed, and are raised again (11:1–14). The seventh trumpet contains no specific event but inaugurates hymns that praise God for his triumph and judgments (11:15–19).

Seven significant signs (12:1–14:20). John interrupts his numbered septets to give a series of visions. But the number seven, so obviously basic to Revelation, is not abandoned, since the events narrated in these visions are seven in number: a woman who gives birth to a son (12:1–6); a war in heaven between Michael and his angels and a dragon, identified with Satan, who is cast out of heaven (12:7–12); a war on earth between Satan and the woman and her child (12:13–13:1a); the worldwide worship of a beast who comes out of the sea (13:1b–10); the worldwide domination of a beast who comes out of the earth (13:11–18); the praise of the Lamb from the 144,000 (14:1–5); and the harvesting of the earth, done by "one like a son of man" and angels (14:14–20). As with the first two septets (seals and trumpets), there is a vision inserted between the sixth and the seventh in this series (see 14:6–13).

The seven bowls (15:1–16:21). John now sees "in heaven another great and marvelous sign: seven angels with the seven last plagues" (15:1). Those who had triumphed over the beast sing praises to God (15:2–4) as the angels come out of the temple with the plagues (15:5–8). These plagues are then described with the imagery of bowls that the angels pour out on the earth (16:1). The pouring out of the bowls brings, successively, painful sores "on the people who had the mark of the beast and worshiped his image" (16:2), a turning of the sea into blood (16:3), a turning of the rivers and springs of water into blood (16:3–7), scorching heat from the sun (16:8–9), destruction of the beast's dominion (16:10–11), the drying up of the Euphrates River and the coming of evil spirits in preparation for "the battle on the great day of God Almighty" at "Armageddon" (16:12–16), and, climactically, the "it is done" of utter earthly destruction (16:17–21).

The triumph of Almighty God (17:1–21:8). These visions describe and celebrate the triumph of God in the world, as his sovereignty, seen by John in heaven in chapter 4, is now manifested in the world—and the world to come. John depicts both the judgment of the wicked and the reward of the righteous. His first vision reveals the evil and destiny of "the great prostitute," "the great city that rules over the kings of the earth" (17:1–18). This great city, named Babylon to suggest an ungodly suppressor of God's people, is now condemned and destroyed, as those who profited from her mourn her (18:1–19:5). In the midst of judgment, however, is salvation, as John hears the praise of a great multitude who had been invited to

share in the wedding supper of the Lamb (19:6–10). John next portrays the victory over the beasts and the assembled nations won by the rider on a white horse (19:11–21). There follows John's famous description of the "thousand years" (hence the "millennium"), during which Satan is bound, and which separates the "first" resurrection from the second (20:1–6). John then depicts the final rebellion and destruction of Satan (20:7–10) and God's judgment of all the dead before the great white throne (20:11–15). The passing of the first earth leads to John's vision of "a new heaven and a new earth." Here God resides with his people (21:2–5), and the righteous are separated from the wicked (21:6–8).

The new Jerusalem (21:9–22:9). This section has many parallels with the angelic vision in 17:1–19:10. In his vision, John sees the "bride, the wife of the Lamb," in the image of a new Jerusalem, whose features and dimensions are described in considerable detail (21:9–21). There will be no need for temple or sun or moon in this city, for God and the Lamb are there, and there will be no wickedness (21:22–22:5). In a transitional section, John climaxes his prophecy with the quotation of Jesus promising to come again soon and a final reference to his own visionary experience (22:6–9).

Epilogue (22:10–21). John is promised that the message contained in the visions he has seen is "trustworthy and reliable" and that there will be reward for those who are faithful and true. This reward is brought by Jesus himself, who is "coming quickly."

AUTHOR

Early Christian Testimony

As early as the middle of the second century, Revelation was ascribed to John, "one of the apostles of Christ" (Justin, *Dial*. 81.4). Other second-century works and writers make the same claim: a lost commentary on Revelation by Melito, bishop of Sardis (c. A.D. 165; see Eusebius, *H.E*. 4.26.2); Irenaeus (c. 180; *Adv. Haer*. 3.11.1, 4.20.11, 4.35.2); and the Muratorian Canon (A.D. 180–200?). Whether Papias, an even earlier witness than these (d. c. 130), can be added to this list is disputed, but a good case can be made that he both knew Revelation and attributed it to John. The evidence of these writers is particularly strong in that two of them (three, if Papias is included) could well be reporting firsthand evidence. Sardis, where Melito was bishop, was one of the churches addressed in Revelation (1:11; 3:1–6). Irenaeus was from Smyrna, also a church addressed in Revelation (1:11; 2:8–11), and claims to have heard Polycarp, who had talked with John the apostle himself. Papias knew John the apostle personally. The early tradition is confirmed by the third-century fathers Tertullian, Hippolytus, and Origen. Not only do these authors ascribe Revelation to John the apostle, but they do so without any hint of there being a contrary claim. No New Testament book, concludes Gerhard Maier, has a stronger or earlier tradition about its authorship than does Revelation.

Nevertheless, the association of John the apostle with Revelation, while early and widespread, is not unanimous. Marcion rejected the book (but then he rejected most of the New Testament, including the Gospel of John). The second-century group called the "Alogoi" also rejected the apostolic origin of Revelation, suggesting that it was written by Cerinthus. But particularly clear and strong in his dissent from the tradition of apostolic authorship was Dionysius, a third-century bishop of Alexandria. As recorded by Eusebius (*H.E*. 7.25.7–27), Dionysius claimed on three grounds that John the apostle could not have written Revelation: (1) the author of Revelation makes no claim to be an apostle or eyewitness and does not describe himself, as does the author of the Gospel of John, as "the beloved disciple"; (2) the conceptions and arrangement of Revelation are completely different from those of the fourth gospel and 1 John; and (3) the Greek of Revelation differs drastically from the Greek of the fourth gospel and 1 John. If then (as Dionysius thought), John the apostle wrote the gospel and 1 John, he could not have written Revelation.

Revelation must have been written by some other person named John; in fact, Dionysius had heard it said that there were two tombs of significant Christians named John in Ephesus.

Dionysius' views are shared by most contemporary scholars, and we will examine the arguments below. For the moment, we want to estimate the value of his witness as an ancient authority. This value is not great. Dionysius makes no claim to be passing on tradition; his rejection of apostolic authorship is based entirely on arguments from the content of Revelation. Moreover, his arguments themselves are motivated by theological bias. Several early Fathers (e.g., Justin, Irenaeus, Tertullian) interpreted Revelation 20:1–6 as teaching what was called *chiliasm*, the doctrine that Christ would establish a thousand-year reign on earth (usually called premillennialism today). Other church fathers, however, found this doctrine abhorrent because of its alleged Jewish roots and materialism. Dionysius was one of these, and his rejection of apostolic authorship of Revelation has as its purpose the discrediting of its alleged chiliastic teaching. This does not mean that Dionysius was wrong or that his arguments are therefore without force. But it does mean that his opinion, being independent of any tradition and motivated by polemical concerns, will be only as valuable as the arguments he uses to support it.

Contemporary Discussion

1. Internal Evidence. Revelation claims to be written by "John" (1:1, 4, 9; 22:8). Addressing himself to his readers, he calls himself "your brother and companion in the suffering and kingdom and patient endurance that are ours in Jesus" (1:9). The author, however, never makes any other claims about himself, and this suggests that he was someone well known to his readers. Which John would have been better known to the churches of Asia Minor in the late first century than John the apostle, whom reliable early church tradition places in Ephesus at the end of his life (see below)? The author's claim to be mediating prophetic words that are authoritative for the readers (e.g., 22:9, 18–19) has also been seen to be indicative of apostolic authorship. While there is something to this argument, it must be admitted that people other than apostles were gifted with prophecy in the early church; that authority, even scriptural authority, does not depend on apostolic status (e.g., Mark, Luke, the author to the Hebrews); and that the authority of Revelation comes more from the One who revealed the visions than from the author himself. Nevertheless, the author's assumption that what he relates will be accepted by the readers simply on the basis of his name alone points more naturally to an apostle than to someone else.

2. Arguments against Apostolic Authorship. Despite this internal evidence, the majority of contemporary scholars deny that John the apostle wrote Revelation. Their reasons for doing so are essentially the same as those of Dionysius.

Lack of apostolic claims. First, it is claimed that the author cannot be an apostle. He never claims to be such, never alludes to gospel events, and never claims a special relationship with Christ. Furthermore, passages such as 18:20 and 21:14, with their allusions to the significant role of the apostles, show that the author was not numbered among the Twelve.

This argument carries little weight. The author's failure to mention his apostolic status may well be because he is so well known to those to whom he writes that such an identification is not needed. Reference to the events of Jesus' life or to any personal relationship between the author and Jesus would be out of place in a book like Revelation. And the significance accorded to the apostles is no greater than that found in passages such as Ephesians 2:20 (and see Matt. 16:17–19).

Theological differences. Both other key arguments against John the apostle as the author of Revelation depend for their validity on the assumption that the apostle wrote the fourth gospel and the Epistles of John. These arguments will therefore not be convincing to the many contemporary critics who deny that

John the apostle wrote the fourth gospel or the Johannine Epistles. But we have argued in this book that John the apostle did write these books, and we must, then, reckon with the problems that confront any attempt to establish unity of authorship for all the Johannine books.

The first of the problems is that the theology of Revelation appears to be quite distinct from that of the fourth gospel and of 1 John. This emerges particularly in three doctrines: theology proper, Christology, and eschatology. The God of Revelation, it is argued, is a God of majesty and judgment, whereas the God of the gospel and the epistles is a God of love. A similar contrast is found in Christology: while the fourth gospel focuses on Christ as revealer and redeemer, Revelation pictures Christ as conquering warrior and ruler. The fourth gospel is frequently said to exhibit "realized eschatology," a view of history and eternity in which "the last things" are viewed as completely realized in the incarnation, death, and resurrection of Christ. Revelation, on the other hand, focuses almost exclusively on a coming of Christ at the end of history. The same author, it is then concluded, cannot be responsible for both books; the theological perspective is too different.

But the contrasts are both overdrawn and incapable of proving much. Both the fourth gospel and Revelation teach that God is *both* loving and judging, that Christ is *both* redeemer and sovereign Lord, and that "the last things" have *both* been realized in Jesus' death and resurrection (at least in principle) and await the end of history for their consummation. Differences between John's gospel and Revelation on these points have been magnified by a narrow and one-sided interpretation of the fourth gospel. That the theological emphases of the fourth gospel and of Revelation are different, no one can deny. But the different settings and purposes for the two books adequately explain these differences in emphasis. There is no reason on such grounds to think the same person could not have written both. Indeed, there is much evidence suggesting commonality of authorship: the description in both books of Jesus as "Word" (John 1:1; Rev. 19:13), "lamb" (John 1:29; Rev. 5:6 and elsewhere—although different Greek words are used) and "shepherd"; a "replacement of the temple" theme (John 4:21; Rev. 21:22); a love of antithesis (darkness-light, truth-falsehood); and many others.

Stylistic differences. Dionysius's third argument against unity of authorship between the fourth gospel and Revelation is the most telling: the differences in the Greek. The Greek of Revelation, as R. H. Charles has commented, is "unlike any Greek that was ever penned by mortal man." Particularly striking are the many grammatical solecisms, or irregularities. One example is the neglect of the proper case after a preposition, as in 1:4: ἀπὸ ὁ ὤν καὶ ὁ ἦν καὶ ὁ ἐρχόμενος (*apo ho on kai ho en kai ho erchomenos*: "from him who is, and who was, and who is to come," TNIV). Charles concluded that it was the Greek of one who was thinking in Hebrew while writing in Greek. Stephen Thompson has shown further that it was biblical rather than postbiblical Hebrew or Aramaic that influenced the author and that Revelation is almost certainly not a translation of an original Hebrew or Aramaic work. In contrast, the Greek of the fourth gospel, while simple and having its share of Semitisms, is accurate and clear. Most contemporary scholars agree with Dionysius: the same person could not have written both books.

Nevertheless, many scholars have attempted to explain the differences in a way that would be compatible with common authorship. Hort and Westcott suggested that a great amount of time intervened between the two books, John having written Revelation in the late 60s and the fourth gospel in the 90s. But it is doubtful that the books can be dated so far apart; nor does the passage of time in itself explain the differences. Others argue that the differences are due to the fact that John, exiled in Patmos, is writing without the aid of an amanuensis that he was able to use for the gospel and the epistles. There may be some truth to this, but it is doubtful that the Greek of Revelation can be set down to inadequate knowledge of the language, for the author is not at all consistent in his breaking of grammatical rules. In the example cited above, for instance, the author goes on in the very same verse to use the correct case after the same

preposition (ἀπὸ τῶν ἑπτὰ πνευμάτων [*apo tōn hepta pneumatōn*]: "from the seven spirits," TNIV). As Charles made clear in his magisterial treatment of the grammar of Revelation, the author follows certain rules of his own, and his solecisms appear to be deliberate. Many scholars therefore think that the author deliberately chose to write Greek as he did perhaps because of the immediacy of the visionary experience, or as a protest against the upper classes. Another factor to keep in mind is the genre difference between the gospel and Revelation. Whatever genre we finally assign to Revelation, its striking difference in form from the gospel is quite clear, and this likely had an impact (perhaps a serious impact) on the Greek style. Whatever his reason, if the author of Revelation has written as he has deliberately, then it is not clear that the person who wrote the fourth gospel could not also have written Revelation. As G. B. Caird says, "Because a man writes in Hebraic Greek, it does not inevitably follow that this is the only Greek he is capable of writing." And, before leaving this matter of the language, we must point out that, as in the case of the theology of the two books, the Greek style of the two shows many similarities.

Conclusion

While the difference in Greek style is a problem, we are not convinced that the arguments of Dionysius or his latter-day followers make it impossible for the same person to have written both the fourth gospel and Revelation. We are thus inclined to accept the testimony of those who were in a position to know about these matters, and we attribute both books to John the apostle, "the beloved disciple."

If this identification is rejected, then there are four other possibilities. First, Revelation could have been written by another well-known John in the ancient church. Dionysius, after suggesting (and properly rejecting) John Mark, mentions a second John (in addition to the apostle John) buried in Ephesus. This second John is often identified with an "elder John" whom Papias mentions (see Eusebius, *H.E.* 3.39.4–5), and this "elder John" is thought by some to have written Revelation. But it is doubtful whether Papias refers to two different men named John at all (see the section "Author" in chap. 6); the whole thesis is most improbable. Another well-known John in the early church was John the Baptist, and J. Massyngberde Ford has suggested that he could be responsible for much of Revelation. But her theory is too far-fetched to command assent (see "Composition and Genre" below).

A second possibility is that Revelation, like Jewish apocalypses, is pseudonymous—written by an unknown person in John's name. But Charles has shown this hypothesis to be unlikely, and it is rarely argued.

Much more popular of late has been a third option: that Revelation, like the other Johannine books, was written by an anonymous member of a Johannine "school" or "circle." Such a hypothesis seems to offer an attractive solution to the problem of explaining both the similarities and differences among these books. Yet, as A. Y. Collins says, the hypothesis "is clearly not the result of careful historical-critical research, but a prior assumption that shapes the result of the research." We have elsewhere argued that the "school" or "circle" hypothesis is untenable (see esp. chap. 6, the section "Stylistic Unity and the Johannine 'Community' ").

We are left, then, as the only real alternative to John the apostle's authorship, authorship by an unknown John, and this is the explanation held by most who demur from the traditional identification. Yet we might question whether a John who is never mentioned in the abundant sources for first-century Asian church life would have had sufficient stature to write a book of this sort, so different from anything else in the New Testament, simply under his own name. Particularly does this seem unlikely when we recall that there *was* a John who was well known in this area at just this period. Guthrie's question is to the point:

"Was the Asiatic church overrun with brilliant Christians by the name of John, who would only need to announce their name for the Christians to know which was meant?"

PROVENANCE

John writes from Patmos, a rocky and rugged island about six miles wide and ten miles long, some forty miles southwest of Ephesus in the Aegean Sea. The island was used by Roman authorities as a place of exile (see Pliny, *Nat. Hist*. 4.23), and John indicates that this was his reason for being there: "because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus" (1:9). Early tradition (e.g., Origen) says that the emperor himself condemned John to exile in Patmos, but it is more likely, considering John's extensive ministry in Asia Minor, that it was a local Roman official from this region who sent John to Patmos is order to get him out of the way.

DATE

Early Christian Testimony

Early Christian writers date Revelation in the reign of one of four different Roman emperors (see Table 8).

Contemporary Discussion

As can be seen from Table 8, a date for Revelation in the reign of Domitian, and probably toward the end of that reign (c. 95–96), receives the most support from the early church fathers. Irenaeus, a key source for this tradition, was in the position, as we noted above, to have direct information about the matter. Most scholars have been inclined to follow Irenaeus in his dating of Revelation at the close of the reign of Domitian. Dates in the reign of Claudius or Trajan are, respectively, too early and too late, and have attracted virtually no adherents. A date shortly after the reign of Nero (68–69), however, has considerable support and is the main alternative to the Domitianic date. There are six key areas of evidence to consider in coming to a decision.

Table 8

Early Christian Writings and the Date of the Revelation

Emperor	Ruled	Sources dating Revelation by emperor
Claudius	41–54	Epiphanius, *Haer* 51.12
Nero	54–68	Syriac versions of Revelation

Domitian	81–96	Irenaeus (*Adv. Haer.* 5.30.3) ("toward the end of the reign of Domitian"); Victorinus, *Apoc.* 10.11; Eusebius, *H.E.* 3.18; Clement of Alexandria (*Quis div.* 42) and Origen (*Matt.* 16.6) both locate Revelation in the reign of "the tyrant," probably referring to Domitian
Trajan	98–117	A synopsis of the life and death of the prophets attributed to Dorotheus; Theophylact on Matt. 20:22

The persecution of Christians. The degree to which the Christians to whom John writes were being persecuted is debated. While many have thought that the book presupposes a widespread, intense, officially promulgated persecution, most recent scholars are more cautious. An extreme view is that virtually no persecution was occurring; it was only John's hostility toward Roman society that led him to speak as if persecution were occurring. But the emerging consensus seems to be that many Christians were indeed being persecuted, that this persecution came from both Jews and the general populace, that the government may have been behind some of the persecution, and that John expected the persecution to worsen in the very near future. Advocates of the Domitianic date have generally appealed to the early Christian tradition that pictured the years 95–96 as a period of intense persecution. Advocates of the earlier date, for their part, point out that the evidence for this persecution is quite slim. The clearest evidence comes from later writers (Orosius, Eusebius, Sulpicius Severus); whereas those more contemporary to Domitian's time, both Christian and pagan, say nothing about a systematic persecution of Christians. In contrast, evidence for a persecution of Christians under Nero is clear and irrefutable. Although we have no evidence that Nero's persecution extended beyond Rome, if we are looking for a period when Christians in Asia Minor were likely to be persecuted, a time during which Christians were being persecuted elsewhere is more likely than a time when we are not sure that they were being persecuted at all.

Advocates of an early date have a point: many scholars have exaggerated the evidence for a persecution of Christians under Domitian. The evidence suggests rather that Domitian in the last years of his reign instituted a purge of Roman aristocrats who might challenge his power. The wife of one of those purged, Domitilla, whose husband, Flavius Clemens, was executed, was probably a Christian, although it is not clear that either she or her husband were singled out because of her faith. There is little evidence, however, that the Neronian persecution of Christians in Rome had lasting effects or spread to the provinces. Advocates of neither date can thus appeal to solid evidence for persecution in Asia Minor. We are confined to assumptions, and the assumption of persecution of Christians in Asia Minor under Nero has no more to be said for it than a similar persecution under Domitian (see the next point).

Worship of the emperor. The conclusion just reached must be modified in light of another consideration: the assumption within Revelation that worship of the emperor had become an issue for Christians (see 13:4, 15–16; 14:9–11; 15:2; 16:2; 19:20; 20:4). We have no solid evidence for the date at which the emperors made worship of their own person a requirement, but there is clear evidence that Domitian stressed his deity, ordering that he be addressed as *dominus et deus* ("lord and god"). Domitian apparently made this confession a test of loyalty. It is indeed possible that some Christians tried to avoid the predicament this placed them in by taking refuge in the synagogue, where some of the traditional legal exceptions granted Jews in this regard still applied. This may help explain the tensions between Jews and Christians evident in the letters to the seven churches. In response to this reasoning, advocates of the earlier date appeal to the fact that emperors since Augustus (d. A.D. 14) had made claims to deity and that, granted Nero's character, it is quite possible that he could have stressed such claims. But the fact remains that our hard evidence points to the last years of Domitian as being the time when Christians would most likely have collided with the claims of the emperor cult.

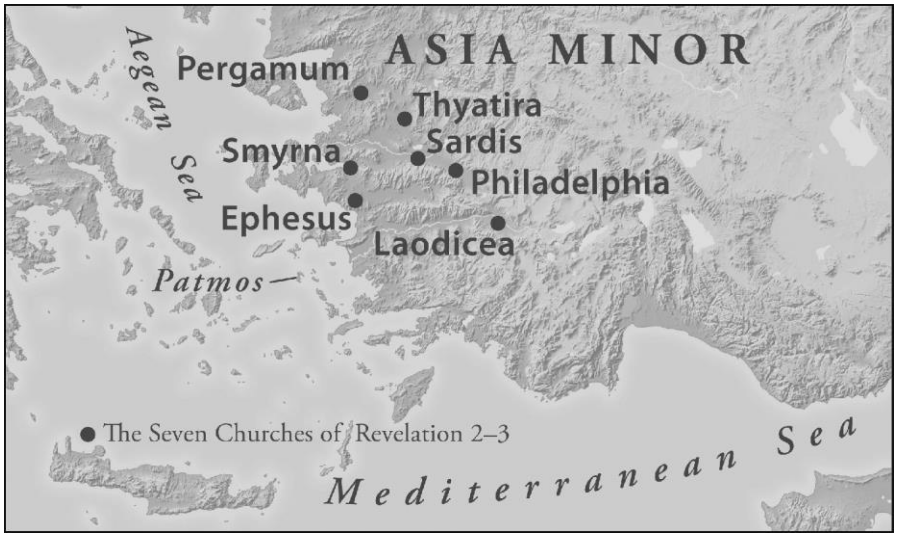
The conditions of the churches. Several elements in the letters to the seven churches are said to be much more compatible with a date in the 90s than one in the 60s: the spiritual stagnation in several of the churches; the wealth of the Laodicean church (the city was destroyed by an earthquake in A.D. 60–61); the existence of the church at Smyrna (the church may not have existed until 60–64); the lack of any mention of Paul, who had labored in Ephesus for so long, and perhaps as late as 64. Not all these points are equally persuasive, but Colin Hemer, after an exhaustive study of the local settings of the churches, claims that his findings generally confirm the Domitianic date.

The existence of a Nero myth. Popular hatred and fear of Nero led to stories circulating after his death to the effect that he would return to Rome leading a Parthian army. Passages in Revelation that speak of the beast recovering from a mortal wound (e.g., 13:3–4), it is argued, allude to a Nero-redivivus myth, and it must have taken time for the myth to circulate and become known. However, the Nero myth is not really very close to what is actually said of the beast in the Revelation, so the argument carries little weight. Moreover, many of those who argue that the number 666 in 13:18 is a cryptic reference to Nero hold that this link is entirely independent of such a myth.

The existence of the Jerusalem temple. Revelation 11:1–2, it is argued, presumes that the temple in Jerusalem was still standing at the time Revelation was written. This argument is not without force, but it is mitigated by two considerations: the possibility that John is using a source; and, more important, the possibility that John refers to a rebuilt or metaphoric temple rather than to the temple of Jesus' day.

Revelation 17:9–11. This passage enumerates seven kings, who are apparently to be taken as emperors of Rome (the allusion to the seven hills in v. 9 is unmistakably a reference to Rome). "Five," says John, "have fallen, one is, the other has not yet come; but when he does come, he must remain for a little while. The beast who once was, and now is not, is an eighth king. He belongs to the seven and is going to his destruction." The assumption of the text is that the sixth king in the sequence is now in power. Taking these data, and beginning with the first of the Roman emperors, Augustus, brings us to Galba, who reigned only a short time after the death of Nero. Here, then, is what appears to be a relatively objective indication that Revelation was written in A.D. 68–69.

The Seven Churches of the Book of Revelation



This argument carries some weight, but it is not decisive because the text is not entirely clear. Is it referring to emperors in John's day or to future kings? Should we start counting the emperors from Augustus; or from Julius Caesar, who first claimed imperial rights; or perhaps from Caligula, the first persecuting emperor? Should we include the three minor emperors who reigned for only very brief periods in 68–69? None of these questions can be answered certainly.

Conclusion

Various other minor points are disputed, but these cover the main arguments. The last two factors appear to favor a date shortly after Nero, but the conditions generally presumed in Revelation are more likely to have existed in the reign of Domitian than earlier (the second and third points). We are inclined, then, to follow the oldest tradition on this point and date Revelation in the last years of Domitian.

DESTINATION

John directs the record of his visions to seven churches in the Roman province of Asia, which incorporated approximately the western third of Asia Minor. These churches were probably personally known to John from years of ministry in the area. His reason for selecting these seven churches, as well as the order in which they are listed, probably has to do with geography and communications. As Ramsay pointed out long ago, the cities in which the churches are located are all centers of communication; a messenger bearing Revelation to the cities would arrive from Patmos in Ephesus, travel by secondary road north to Smyrna and Pergamum, and then go east on the Roman road to Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea.

COMPOSITION AND GENRE

Sources and Theories of Composition

Revelation borrows more extensively from the Old Testament than any other New Testament book. Most of the references come not in explicit quotations but in allusions and conceptual borrowings. John also makes use of Jewish apocalyspses, though to a lesser degree than is sometimes thought. Some have thought that John also betrays a knowledge of several New Testament books: Charles lists Matthew, Luke, 1 Thessalonians, 1 and 2 Corinthians, Colossians, and Ephesians. But this is not so clear, since almost all the similarities could have arisen from John's knowledge of the oral tradition of Jesus' life and teaching and of

general early Christian teachings. Still, since it is likely that John had read at least Mark and Luke by this date (on their dates, see "Date" in chaps. 4 and 5 above), we must allow the possibility of direct borrowing.

During the heyday of source analysis of the Scriptures in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, a number of scholars found evidence of sources behind the canonical book of Revelation. Charles, for instance, thinks one-fifth of the book is dependent on written sources, Greek and Hebrew in language and Jewish and Christian in origin. He also argues that the author of most of the book died before finishing it and that "a faithful but unintelligent disciple" pasted together the material in 20:4–22:21, but in an order radically different from what the author intended. But Charles's rearrangement of the material causes more problems than it solves. Neither has his identification of sources much to be said for it. Revelation demonstrates a consistency in style that prevents any inferences about sources on the basis of linguistic considerations. Moreover, the book is so thoroughly permeated with traditional language and conceptions that it is impossible to identify sources through these means either. Evidence for sources is often found in the existence of doublets, or passages that appear to be roughly parallel. But repetition of material is part of the nature of Revelation.

Undeterred by these hindrances, a number of scholars have gone even further, arguing that the book of Revelation is made up of two or more large blocks of material. Boismard thinks that two parallel apocalypses have been combined. J. Massyngberde Ford argues that chapters 4–11 stem from John the Baptist, and 12–22 from a disciple of John, with 1–3; 22:16a, 20b; 21 being added by a Jewish-Christian disciple. Neither theory has much positive evidence in its favor, but both rest (particularly in Ford's case) on imaginative and implausible connections and inferences. More recently, David Aune has presented a detailed case for a two-stage composition process. He thinks that a "first edition" of the book, containing 1:7–12a and 4:1–22:5 and strongly apocalyptic in flavor, was produced around A.D. 70. A "second edition," adding the remaining sections and redacting the whole toward a more prophetic and parenetic model, was then completed in the early year's of the reign of Trajan. But we doubt whether the data require a two-stage process, which, in any case, seems to fly in the face of John's claims to have received the visions of the book at a single point in time while on Patmos.

Genre

As Beasley-Murray notes, the opening verses of Revelation appear to suggest three different genre identifications: apocalypse (1:1), prophecy (1:3), and epistle (1:4). Each has its defenders, and each plays a role in the complex literary phenomenon of Revelation.

Identification with the genre "apocalypse" or "apocalyptic" is complicated by continuing debate over just what apocalyptic is: Is it a type of eschatology, or is it a literary genre, or both? Current researchers generally answer that it embraces both but that we should distinguish the two, "apocalyptic" being used to describe a certain kind of eschatology, and "apocalypse" to denote a literary genre.

The literary genre apocalypse began to appear in the second century B.C. as a response to persecution and oppression. The authors of apocalypses claim to be passing on heavenly mysteries revealed to them by an angel or some other spiritual being. Apocalypses are typically pseudonymous, written in the name of a great figure in Israel's past (e.g., Adam, Moses, Enoch). By so projecting themselves into the past, the authors of apocalypses can put historical surveys of God's dealings with his people and with the world in the form of prophecy. These historical surveys, which are found in many, though not all, apocalypses, culminate with the breaking in of God's kingdom, which is expected in the very near future.

The writers of apocalypses usually use extensive symbolism in their historical reviews. The kind of eschatology found in these books (though not confined to them) is then called apocalyptic. It is

characterized by a dualistic conception of history: the present world, with its sin, rebellion against God, and persecution of God's people, is sharply contrasted with the world to come, when God will intervene to establish his kingdom. Just at this point "apocalyptic" is often contrasted with "prophecy," which, it is argued, looks for God's salvation to be manifested through the processes of this world rather than through a breaking in of a new world. The prophet is also sometimes contrasted with the apocalypticist in his claim to speak directly from the Lord.

It takes only a casual acquaintance with Revelation to see that it possesses many of the features just described. Its message comes through visions given by angels. It is communicated through extensive use of symbols, strongly contrasts this world with the world to come, and looks for deliverance in the near future. Considering these similarities to Jewish apocalyptic and the apparent claim in 1:1 (the first three words in Greek are Ἀποκάλυψις Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ [*Apokalypsis Iēsou Christou*], "the revelation from Jesus Christ," TNIV), it is no wonder that many scholars are convinced that Revelation belongs in the literary genre apocalypse. Yet there are problems with this identification. The most notable one is the fact that Revelation, unlike Jewish apocalypses, is not pseudonymous. John speaks in his own name. If, then, pseudonymity is considered essential to the genre apocalypse, Revelation clearly cannot be an apocalypse. Others respond, however, by insisting that pseudonymity is not necessary to the genre and that Revelation is an apocalypse "with a difference." And of course there is another difference: Jewish apocalypticists ground their hope in a future event, while John in the Revelation grounds his hope in the past sacrifice of Jesus Christ, the "Lamb that has been slain." This does not necessarily mean that the Revelation is not an apocalyptic book, since modifications to the basic apocalyptic scheme could well be introduced without abandoning the apocalyptic perspective per se. But these issues at least suggest that other genre identifications should be considered.

It is difficult, however, to find another genre to which Revelation belongs. John certainly suggests that he stands in a prophetic role, and there is a tendency in current scholarship to view Revelation as a prophecy. But a better suggestion is to find elements of both prophecy and apocalyptic in Revelation. Despite the impression given by some scholars, no rigid distinction between these two is possible. They are combined in many Old Testament books (e.g., Daniel, Isaiah, Zechariah) and in Jesus' Olivet Discourse. In his consciousness of inspiration and of the authority that he assumes, John is truly a prophet. But his prophecy makes use of the forms current in Jewish apocalypses.

Yet another genre to be considered is epistle. This may seem odd at first, but epistle was a very broad genre (see discussion in chap. 8 above), and Revelation, with its opening address and salutation (1:4–5, 9–11), presents itself as a circular letter to seven churches in Asia Minor. Nevertheless, the contents of Revelation as a whole do not fit altogether naturally the category of epistle. The complicated character of Revelation therefore suggests that we should not place it neatly into one genre category. Elements of prophecy, apocalypse, and letter are combined in a way that has no close parallel in other literature.

TEXT

Kurt and Barbara Aland claim, "In the book of Revelation the textual scene and its history differs greatly from the rest of the New Testament." This is due to two factors. First, Revelation has far fewer Greek manuscript witnesses than any other New Testament book. It originally circulated independently of the rest of the New Testament, and the nature of the book, combined with suspicions about it in the East, where the bulk of Greek manuscripts were produced, cut down the number of copies made. Extant are only five papyrus manuscripts, the longest containing eight chapters (P^{47}, from the third century), and eleven uncials, only six of which contain any substantial portion of text, and only three of which contain the whole book

(Sinaiticus [א], from the fourth century; Alexandrinus [A], from the fifth century; and 046, from the tenth century). The textual critic, then, has much less evidence on which to base decisions. At least the contemporary critic has more to go by than did Erasmus, who, in his first edition, for lack of *any* Greek manuscript evidence for some verses in the Revelation, translated the Latin Vulgate back into Greek!

A second factor that makes the text of Revelation unique is the value of the witnesses that are available. While in most of the New Testament, Sinaiticus (א) is considered to have a text superior to that found in Alexandrinus (A), the situation is reversed in Revelation: Alexandrinus, in combination with Ephraemi (C) (where it is extant), is considered the best text available. Dependence on these uncials is all the more important because one of the most respected uncials for the New Testament text, Vaticanus (B), does not include Revelation. The combination of few witnesses and variant text types requires that textual decisions in Revelation be based on methods appropriate to its own peculiar text situation.

ADOPTION INTO THE CANON

Revelation may be alluded to by Ignatius (A.D. 110–117) and Barnabas (before 135) and is probably used by the author of the *Shepherd of Hermas* (c. 150). As we noted above under "Author," Revelation is quoted as authoritative by (perhaps) Papias (d. 130), Justin (middle of the second century), and Irenaeus (180), and is found in the Muratorian Canon (180–200?). Marcion rejected Revelation from his canon (see Tertullian, *Adv. Marc*. 4.5), but this is not surprising, since he rejected any New Testament book that smacked of the Old Testament or Judaism—and Revelation is filled with Old Testament allusions. Eusebius also mentions that Revelation was rejected by a Gaius, a church official in Rome at the beginning of the second century (*H.E*. 3.28.1–2). His reason was probably the use to which the Montanists, a Christian sect that stressed prophecy and the nearness of the eschaton, were putting Revelation. By denying canonical status to one of their most important books, Gaius could hope to discredit the movement. The same reason probably lies behind the rejection of Revelation on the part of the group known as the "Alogoi." In any case, these scattered rejections of Revelation in the Western church did not affect its canonicity, and from this point forward there is no hint of doubt about Revelation's full canonical status in the West.

The situation in the East was quite different. The authority accorded to Revelation by Papias and Justin was seconded by third-century scholars such as Clement of Alexandria and Origen. But the Egyptian bishop Dionysius disagreed. As we have seen, he questioned the apostolic authorship of the book in an effort to minimize its authority. His questions led other churchmen in the East to question its canonicity, among them Eusebius, who says that many in his day questioned its status (*H.E*. 3.25.1–4). The Council of Laodicea (360) did not recognize it as canonical, and it is omitted from the earliest editions of the Syriac Peshitta.

At first sight, these doubts about Revelation seem somewhat disturbing. But on closer examination, they can be seen to be somewhat extraneous to the issue of canonicity. As Maier has shown in great detail, the doubts about Revelation stemmed from no considered argument or historical knowledge but were the result of distaste for the eschatology of the book. Revelation seemed to teach, and was interpreted by many in the early church to teach, a doctrine of the last things that was too earthly focused, too materialistic for many of the Eastern fathers. We should not, then, be much influenced by them in our assessment of the canonicity of the book. A similar point must be made about latter-day critics of the Revelation. Luther, for instance, relegated it to a secondary status in his New Testament, saying, "My spirit cannot accommodate itself to this book. There is one sufficient reason for the small esteem in which I hold it—that Christ is neither taught nor recognized." One might wonder at this point whether Luther was reading the same book that we have in our Bibles, the book that makes "the Lamb that was slain" the

linchpin in God's plan for history and the end of history. At any rate, such theological prejudice should not be allowed to affect our judgments about the book's rightful place in the canon.

REVELATION IN RECENT STUDY

Scholarship on Revelation, in keeping with New Testament scholarship generally, has moved away from a concern with sources and historical background to a concern with the final literary product and its setting. Attention has been given to the genre of Revelation (see above) and to the genre of the letters to the seven churches, as well as to the structure and literary techniques of the book. The social-theological setting out of which the book arose has also been investigated, one of the more interesting theories being that the Revelation is the product of a Christian "prophetic circle." Collins has used sociological theories to argue that John was writing to help his readers find a new identity and to learn to cope with their sense of having failed to meet their own expectations. Several other studies combine a focus on the social context of Revelation, with particular perspectives on language and rhetoric. These tend to distinguish between the actual world in which John lived, and the world that he perceived and created in the Revelation. The book is "deconstructed," stripped of the particular biases that John brought to the interpretations of his visions. Study of the Revelation continues to be affected also by continuing research into apocalyptic, which is now focusing on the wider dimensions of the movement and on its social matrix.

Other studies, more traditional in their orientation, have also appeared. John's Greek continues to be the subject of interest, with two recent monographs on the subject. Alan James Beagley, in a monograph on the enemies of the church in Revelation, concludes that Jewish-Christian antipathy plays a key role in the book. Two studies stand out in particular. The first is Colin J. Hemer's study of the setting of the seven churches of the Revelation, in which the student of Revelation is provided with a cornucopia of background data that sheds new light on the text. The second in the magisterial study by Gerhard Maier of the interpretation of, and attitude toward, Revelation in the history of the church. His work puts to rest many of the theories about Revelation that tend to undercut its apostolic origin or canonical status.

THE CONTRIBUTION OF REVELATION

Methods of Interpretation

Any estimate of the contribution of Revelation to our understanding of Christ and the gospel demands some decision about the basic intent and subject matter of the book. What do John's visions refer to? What are we to learn from them? The church has never come to anything close to unanimity on this point. As Gerhard Maier says after his survey of interpretations, Revelation has been "the exercise field of hermeneutics par excellence." We may categorize the majority of interpretations under the usual four headings.

The preterist approach. This approach, also known as the "contemporary-historical" *(zeitgeschichtlich)*, is the most common today. It insists that the visions of John grow out of and describe events in John's own day. The symbols in the visions all refer to people, countries, and events in the world of that day; and John's purpose is to exhort his readers to remain faithful to Christ as they wait for God to deliver them into his eternal kingdom.

The historical approach. Several movements in the Middle Ages grew up in the conviction that the millennium was about to dawn. To buttress their beliefs, they found in the Revelation a sketch of history from the time of Christ to their own day. This approach (the *kirchengeschichtlich*) was popular with the Reformers also, enabling them to identify the beast in the Revelation with the papacy.

The futurist approach. A consistently futurist (or *endgeschichtlich*) approach holds that everything in the Revelation from chapter 4 to the end finds its fulfillment in the very last days of human history. The view is also held in a more moderate form, according to which some of the events in these chapters—particularly the earlier ones—take place in history before the end.

The idealist approach. Some scholars are convinced that we are on the wrong track altogether in trying to identify the events portrayed in John's visions. The symbolism is designed, they argue, to help us understand God's person and ways with the world in a general way, not to enable us to map out a course of events. Revelation, then, teaches us "the action of great principles and not special incidents."

Along with several recent commentators, we find some truth in all four of these views. Yet it is the futurist approach that comes closest to doing justice to the nature and purposes of Revelation. As we have seen, Revelation adapts and modifies the apocalyptic perspective. Jewish apocalyptic writers projected themselves back into time so that they could describe the imminent breaking into history of God's eternal kingdom as the culmination of history. By writing in his own name, John discards the historical survey and confronts his readers with an elaborate vision of the establishment of Christ's reign in history. Revelation is about eschatology, not history.

Nevertheless, the peculiar eschatological stance of the early church demands that we not ignore the degree to which John pictures this eschatological climax against the backdrop of events in his own day. It is likely, for instance, that John's depiction of the "great prostitute," "Babylon," that is doomed to fall (18:1–4), has some reference to the Roman Empire of his own day, and that the terrible persecution described in Revelation would remind John's readers of their own oppression. To some extent, then, John, while describing the end, describes it against the background of his first-century situation. But this is typical of biblical prophecy in both Old and New Testaments. While revealing his plan for history, God has not often revealed its timing; and biblical prophets have always pictured "the day of the Lord," the eschaton, in terms of their own time. Moreover, it is clear that history itself contains many prefigurements of that end; John himself reminds us that, while "the antichrist is coming, even now many antichrists have come" (1 John 2:18).

The Contribution of Revelation

Revelation makes significant contributions to a number of areas of New Testament theology. It conveys a sense of the sovereignty of God that no other New Testament book approaches. The vision of God on his throne and of the worship he receives helps us to see beyond our earthly circumstances to the Lord of earth and heaven and reminds us that only God is ultimately worthy of our devotion and praise. As Richard Bauckham puts it, "The effect of John's visions, one might say, is to expand his readers' world, both spatially (into Heaven) and temporally (into the eschatological future), is, to put it another way, to open their world to divine transcendence."

Revelation offers a high Christology, in that Jesus is constantly portrayed in terms appropriate only to God. It is significant in this regard, as Beasley-Murray points out, that the opening vision of the book is not of God the Father but of Jesus Christ (1:12–20) and that both God the Father and Jesus Christ are called "the Alpha and the Omega" (1:8; 22:13). In these ways and in many others, John makes clear that the sovereign God is accomplishing his purposes on earth through the Son, very God himself.

But while the Revelation focuses on Christ's glory, power, and role in judgment, the cross is never out of sight. The powerful rider on the white horse, we are constantly reminded, is none other than the "lamb that was slain." Without dwelling on the crucifixion of Christ, John makes it clear that all that Christ does to

wrap up human history is rooted in his sacrificial death. John has restructured the typical Jewish apocalyptic perspective with his christological focus.

If, as we have argued, Revelation focuses on the end of history, then it is in the area of eschatology that it makes its most important contribution. Nowhere are we given a more detailed description of the events of the end; and while many interpreters have been guilty of finding far more specifics in John's visions than his symbolism allows and of unwisely insisting that only their own circumstances fit those specifics, we should not go to the other extreme and ignore those details that John does make relatively clear.

But it is shortsighted to think of eschatology simply in the sense of what will happen in the end times. For the End, in biblical thought, shapes and informs the past and the present. Knowing how history ends helps us understand how we are to fit into it now. Particularly is this so because the New Testament makes clear that even now we are in "the last days." Thus, Revelation reminds us of the reality and severity of evil, and of the demonic forces that are active in history. Beasley-Murray's comment is insightful: "It is ironical that the century which has witnessed the death of the Devil and the Antichrist in theology has experienced the most appalling manifestations of demonic statecraft, the most terrible desolation of war, and the most widespread oppression of the Christian faith in all history." At the same time, the degree to which Revelation exhorts believers should not be neglected. As the letters to the seven churches in chapters 2–3 reveal, not all the Christians to whom John writes were faithful. There is a conflict in Revelation not only between the church and the world but also within the church.

John's visions also place in clear relief the reality of God's judgment. A day will come when his wrath will be poured out, when sins will have to be accounted for, when the fate of every individual will depend on whether or not his or her name is "written in the Lamb's book of life." Equally clear, of course, is the reward that God has in store for those who "keep the word of endurance" and resolutely stand against the devil and his earthly minions, even at the cost of life itself. John's visions are a source of comfort for suffering and persecuted believers in all ages.

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